

er. Media Center uses an EPG, much like Freeview and subscription TV services, so you can see a schedule of what's coming up over the next seven days and plan what to watch or record. You can also access radio stations and manage your digital photo collection. Unfortunately, Home Basic users don't have this feature.



Control precisely how – and for how long – your children use the computer

6. Make you an icon

Vista takes a new approach to file icons – the thumbnail-size images that represent your documents. Instead of using a single picture that simply denotes which application produced the document, Vista presents an image of the document itself. Open a folder and click the view menu and you have the choice of a number of different sizes that can help you identify the file you're looking for.

7. Protect against crashes

Everyone has experienced the frustration of losing work because their PC crashes. The reasons behind crashes are many, but Vista includes a feature called Resource Exhaustion Prevention, which alerts you when Windows is showing signs that it can't cope, giving you the opportunity to save work quickly and even avoid the crash by closing applications.

8. Work together

If you work with other people on projects that involve a computer, then you have to take a look at Windows Meeting Space. This application lets you set up virtual 'meetings' over a wired or wireless networks, so that people can see documents you're working on and

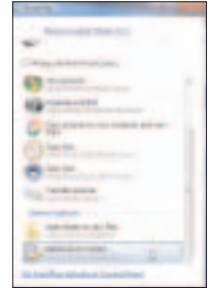


Share and collaborate with Windows Meeting Space

exchange notes with each other. Up to nine people can take part in a Meeting Space session using Vista Home Premium or Ultimate.

9. Boost your memory

The amount of memory in your PC is one of the key elements that dictates its performance. This is of importance when you're working in applications that use lots of memory, such as video-editing packages, or when you have a number of programs running at once. Windows Readyboost is a clever way of adding more memory as needed using USB memory keys or Flash memory cards. When you plug in such a device, Vista will give you the option to use its capacity to boost memory.



Put a removable disk to work

10. Shrink your programs

Gadgets are mini applications that run in the Windows Sidebar (a pane that runs down the side of the screen at all times). You can choose to display either Vista's built-in Gadgets provided or head online for new ones. Calendars, photo viewers, news updates, performance monitors and more can be accessed from your desktop without having to launch a program.



Download new Sidebar Gadgets from the web

11. Stop you getting lost

Vista includes an enhancement to the Windows Explorer navigation bar. The bar now shows not just the folder you are currently navigating but also the folders that you had to open to get there, meaning that there's a visual trail of 'breadcrumbs'. Each folder in the trail has an arrow next to it – click it and Explorer displays the other folders it holds, making it easier to retrace your steps.

12. Cut up your desktop

Vista's Snipping Tool gives you total flexibility, with options to grab the entire screen, a small selection or an area you have select-